against [the] Bolsheviks and in our favour'.[85]

One way to find this out was with the Mussoorie Conference, which took place between British and Afghan delegates in the summer of 1920. As may be recalled, the Anglo-Afghan Treaty of August 1919 had been concluded as a peace treaty only, with an agreement of friendship to follow. Thus, in December 1919, Amanullah wrote to Chelmsford suggesting the conclusion of such an accord.[86] The problem was, however, that the Afghan government had failed to uphold the conditions which the Indian government had set for such a treaty of friendship, including the expulsion of Indian and Bolshevik seditionary characters from Afghan territory. Therefore Chelmsford suggested a meeting between the two sides 'for the purpose of frankly examining any obstacles which may now exist to a good understanding and to preparing a firm foundation on which a treaty of friendship can afterwards be erected'.[87]

Just as with the Rawalpindi negotiations, however, the Home government was suspicious of the emir's calls for friendship with Britain, and wary of the Indian government appearing weak to the Afghans.[88] Nevertheless, in the viceroy's opinion, the Indian government needed to do something to 'dispel this atmosphere of probably genuine suspicion' that was developing in Afghanistan against Britain.[89] As H.R.C. Dobbs (Hamilton Grant's successor as foreign secretary) emphasised, the longer Afghanistan and Britain remained estranged, the more that suspicion between the two nations would grow and the more success Bravin would have in misrepresenting British intentions to the emir and his government.[90]

Thus, on 14 April 1920, a conference between British and Afghan delegates opened in Mussoorie, in the United Provinces of Agra and Oudh. As well as lengthy discussion on issues such as tribal unrest on India's borders, the conference served to confirm the Indian government's opinions on the state of Afghan–Bolshevik relations.[91] On 30 April, the Afghan representatives openly admitted to Dobbs, who was heading the British delegation, that they would much rather be Britain's friend than Soviet Russia's, since Britain: